



SPORTVIEW

By Chauncey Durden

Times-Dispatch Sports Editor

Waiting for Yankees

BASEBALL PLAYERS, and particularly players in a major league farm system, have their own grapevine. Which accounts for a remark dropped by a New York Yankee-owned Virginian pitcher.

"From what we hear," said the pitcher at the Vees' Haines City training camp, "it should be right much fun pitching for Richmond this season."

What the Virginian players hear may be one thing, and what Virginian General Manager Herm Krattenmaker and Field Manager Eddie Lopat hear may be another.

In fact, both Krattenmaker and Lopat say they've heard nothing definite from the New York parent club about the disposal of young and surplus Yankee talent. Two players still on the Yankees' 38-man squad are on the Vees' roster. Those two are Pitcher Johnny James and Outfielder Deron Johnson, sometime known as THE Phenom. James and Johnson unquestionably will join the Virginians before the Yankees break their Florida camp.

Yankee Manager Casey Stengel likes to have a few promising young 'uns about. And Ol' Case seems genuinely fond of James and Johnson. But neither is ready for the Yankees this season.

The same goes for several other youngsters still harboring Stadium hopes. How the Yankee surplus will be divided between Denver and the Virginians, Krattenmaker and Lopat profess not to know. They'll name you players they would like to have, but so will Andy Cohen, the Denver manager.

If the Yankees fail to make a trade before cutting down to the 25-player limit, there should be plenty of talent to bolster both the Vees and Denver.

Breaking down the Yankee squad—the players still under Stengel's crooked wing—there are four catchers, including Elston Howard, who also doubles in the outfield, 16 pitchers, nine infielders and nine outfielders. In addition to Richmond roster-men James and Johnson, there is one other player still with the Yankees who is not on the varsity club's roster. That one is Pitcher Zach Monroe, who pitched for Denver last season and remains on the American Association club's roster. Of course, any or all of the three non-Yankee roster-men—James, Johnson and Monroe—could be switched to the New York roster—if Stengel and Lee MacPhail believed the switch would help the Yankees.

Ten Holdover Pitchers

ASSUMING THE YANKEES do not trade off several of the younger players—and that is strictly an assumption, for the Yankees may yet make the trade with Cleveland that would add Indian Ray Narleski to the Yankee pitching staff—the New York club most likely would carry three catchers (including Catcher-Outfielder Howard), 10 pitchers, seven infielders and five outfielders.

That would mean 13 players still with the Yankees, including James, Johnson and Monroe, would have to be cut by the mid-May deadline.

To go along with Howard behind the plate are Yogi Berra and Darrell Johnson. That would leave John Blanchard, a long-ball hitter who was tabbed two years ago by Bill Dickey as Berra's successor, to be farmed out. The Vees are supposed to get Blanchard, who was with Denver last season, when and if.

There are 10 holdover Yankee pitchers from last season, including Sal Maglie who was purchased from Brooklyn too late last year to be eligible for the World Series. Other holdover pitchers are Whitey Ford, Bobby Shantz, Don Larsen (counted on for an outstanding season), Tom Sturdivant, Johnny Kuchs, Bob Turley, Art Ditmar, Bob Grim and Al Cicotte.

Other pitchers with the Yankee club are James, Monroe, Jim Coates, Ed Dick, Rhyne Duren and Mark Freeman. Off their spring showing, Duren, a fast-balling righthander up from Denver, would seem to have the best chance of sticking. Barring a trade, Coates and Dick are expected to be assigned to the Vees. Lopat naturally would welcome Freeman with Coates, Dick and James.

Who's Where, Case?

THE NINE YANKEE INFIELERS could and would be reduced to eight, should Bobby Richardson go to Cleveland in the still possible Narleski deal. In that event, only John Jakiuk, last year's Vee first baseman, would appear to be on the optional side—to the Virginians. Until Stengel decides who plays shortstop (Gil McDougald or Tony Kubek?) and who plays second base (McDougald, Kubek or Richardson?), Rookie Shortstop Fritz Brickell's immediate future remains unknown.

If there is no deal with Cleveland for Narleski, Brickell might be farmed out. Lopat and/or Cohen would fight a duel for Brickell.

Micky Mantle, Hank Bauer, Enos Slaughter and Suitcase Simpson are holdover Yankee outfielders. Norm Siebern, after leading the American Association in batting last year, will be given every opportunity to make it all the way this season. That leaves Deron Johnson, Bobby Del Greco, Zeke Bella and Dick Sanders (who finished last season at third base for the Vees, but who has been shifted to the outfield). It is questionable whether Del Greco could be waived out of the American League. Lopat would take either Bella or Sanders along with Johnson.

Apparently Washington club officials have been doing some talking about a trade involving Yankee-owned players. At least a Washington baseball writer, who wouldn't know much about the International League, was saying one day before an exhibition game between the Senators and the Detroit Tigers that Washington would like to deal for Vee Pitcher Bill Bethel. A few minutes later the same Washington writer was inquiring about the pronunciation of Jakiuk's name.

It would require a quantity of Senator surplus to make up for the quality of Bethel and Jakiuk. Do the Senators have that quantity?

Until, and when, the Yankees do begin wheeling and dealing young players, the Vees' prospects look mighty good. Even good enough for that pitcher to have his "fun" this season.